

TRITONE SUBS

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #156

Nothing strikes fear into the heart of a novice jazz player like the words "Tritone Sub." We know it's a big deal, and we know we should know about it. And if we DO intellectually understand the concept, how in the world do we actually use a Tritone Sub? And why?

In short, a Tritone Sub gives us a chord we can use in place of another chord. For now, let's use a V chord as an example. Whenever you see a V chord, you can substitute a different chord, the chord built a tritone (augmented 4th) away. Cooler yet, we can let this new chord, the Tritone Sub, inform our melodies. As a soloist or composer, the Tritone Sub can offer us notes and sounds that we wouldn't likely find on our own.

#1 - Typical ii - V - I progression

ii V I V I

#2 - Tritone Sub (ii - bII - I)

ii bII I bII I

#3 - Using a Tritone Sub over a ii - V - I melodically

b5 or #11

Here we are "thinking Db7 material" over the measure of G7.

#4 - Johnny Griffin (Evidence)

Db triad

The Tritone Sub gets us the b9 (Ab) and the #4/b5 (Db) notes here.